

University City

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June 1992

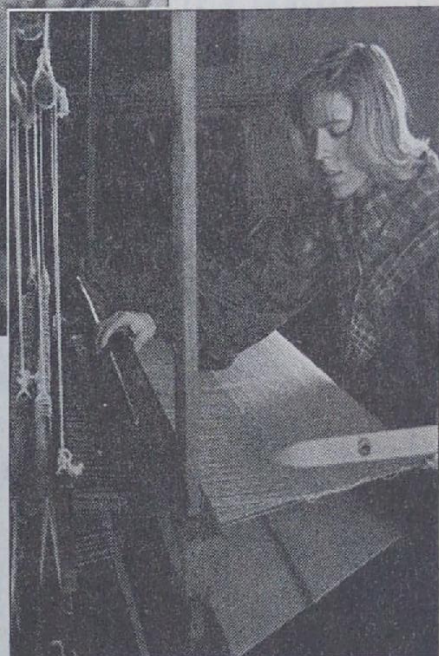
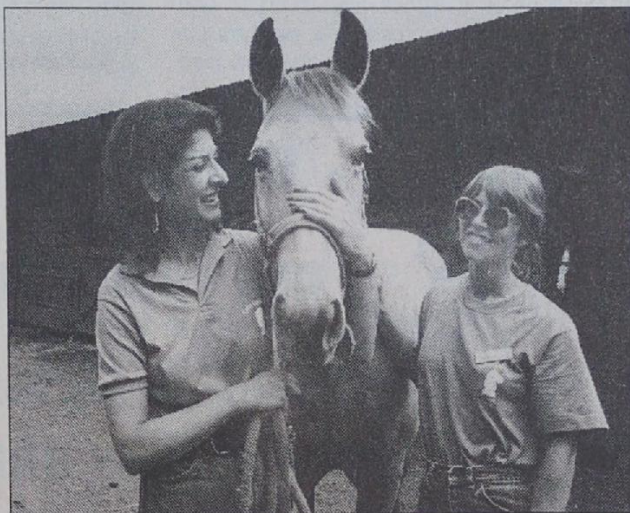
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Going wild in our parks



Latta Plantation Park is full of activities. Among the many you'll be able to sample this month are, clockwise from top left, the Folk Music Festival, tours of Latta Plantation House, and horseback riding at the park's equestrian center.

Just about any way you measure it, Latta Plantation Park is the jewel in the crown of Mecklenburg's park system. And University City residents are blessed, because the park is literally at our back door.

Park visitors can fish from its expansive shoreline, hike miles of forest trails, picnic along Mountain Island Lake, see birds of prey up close, go for a horse ride, paddle a canoe or learn first-hand about Mecklenburg's pioneer days.

The park's extensive equestrian center hosts horse shows just about every weekend in the spring.

Plus, park rangers hold special programs several times each month, ranging from wildflower hikes to canoe trips to story-telling times.

The 800-acre nature preserve will soon grow by another 200 acres, thanks to bond money approved last year by voters. That extra land will make the park not only Mecklenburg's most diverse but also its largest.

Latta Plantation Park is open 7 a.m.-dusk daily. The hours of its many activities vary, so you'll need to check before going.

To get to Latta Plantation Park

from University Place, take Harris Boulevard northwest until you cross I-77. A half-mile west of I-77, the road bears to the right and changes names to Vance Road. Go a mile until it dead-ends at Mt. Holly-Huntersville Road. Turn left and go a mile to Beatties Ford Road. Turn right and go a mile to Sample Road. Turn left. The park is at the end of Sample Road.

The whole ride should take no more than 20 minutes, and after you've gone once, you'll keep going back. The park is a big piece of outdoor heaven, right in our backyards. ■

Going wild in our parks

Hurt birds get new life at Raptor Center

By Gary Eklund

The word "raptor" means "Birds of prey" and comes from Latin, meaning "One who seizes." These birds are primarily eagles, owls,

falcons, hawks and vultures.

You can see them all at the Carolina Raptor Center, a unique facility at Latta Plantation Park where injured raptors are cared for and rehabilitated.

In late May, the center achieved a decade-long goal when it moved into its first permanent home, a 4,000-square-foot building just off the park's main drive.

Raptors are not only beautiful to watch, they are indicators of the planet's environmental health, says raptor center Director Pat Marcum.

Marcum says that because these

winged hunters are at the top of the food chain, as man is of his, they can show us when something toxic is causing problems.



Marcum

"We watch these birds and try to keep them in the environment as a check on our food supply," she says. "...Raptors are part of nature's balance, and it is important that we keep as many birds as healthy as we are able."

Last year the center helped 512 birds from throughout the Carolinas.

The raptor center has come a long way since it began at UNC Charlotte in 1980. It moved to the park in 1984. Until last month, the center was housed in trailers.

The center has a staff of four full-time and one part-time paid employees, plus more than 100 volunteers giving over 10,000 hours a year in time.

Two years ago a patron offered to donate \$100,000 toward a new building. The new building ended up costing approximately \$280,000. Much of the additional \$180,000 has been given as materials.

Donations of time and money are critical to the center. With government support ending in 1991, the raptor center now depends upon memberships (\$25 per person or \$10 for students and seniors) and a small amount of corporate and foundation funding.



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Suite 165
Charlotte, N.C. 28269

548-0500

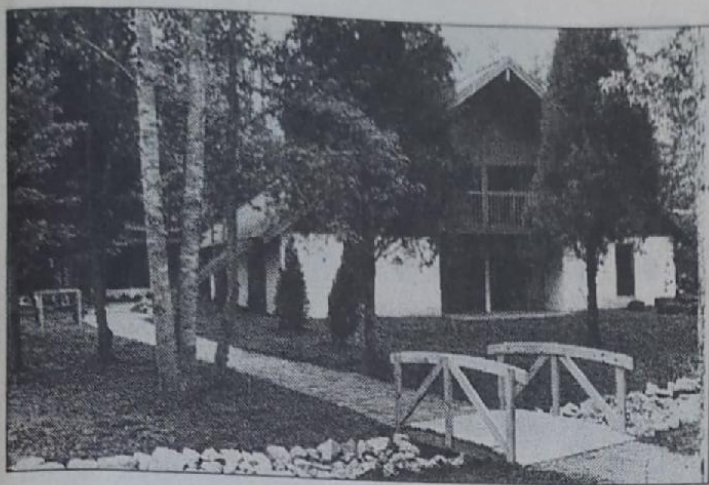
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The new Carolina Raptor Center building at Latta Plantation Park.

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The new center features an exhibit hall, aviary, classrooms and library. There's also a gift shop where visitors can buy T-shirts, books and souvenirs. Proceeds help keep the center afloat.

What the Carolina Raptor Center wishes to do primarily (besides saving raptors' lives), is educate our community about birds of prey and their needs.

The center is open 10 a.m.-5 p.m. Tuesdays-Sundays for visitors, and special group tours can also be arranged.

On a recent morning, third graders from Horner's Nest Elementary School walked the center's shaded paths with volunteer Betty O'Leary. They stopped at a cage housing a Swanson's hawk that was too injured to survive in the wild.

O'Leary posed a question. "There's no more hawks and owls; why do we need hawks and owls?"

Because we like to see birds, said one student. Because there will be more and more rodents, said another.

"That's true," agreed O'Leary. "Birds of prey, because of what they eat, are very important to have out in the world."

In a few more minutes the children would be finished and ready to depart, carrying away a vivid impression of raptors and hopefully new knowledge that will help protect these bellwethers of our world's ecosystem. ■

Want to help?

You can help the Carolina Raptor Center and gain some fame as well, by buying an inscribed brick on the Raptor Center's new patio. A \$35 donation will get you a brick inscribed with your or someone else's name.

For details, call the raptor center at 875-6521.



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Mortgage Consultant

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